

Launch emerging as central focus of global space race

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While SpaceX's Starship launch could improve launch site supply issues, it also intensifies a bottleneck for SpaceX's satellite competitors.

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Countries will continue efforts to build sovereign satellite capabilities and extend them to launch, given reliance on SpaceX rockets.

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Frontier reusable space vehicle capability will give the US a battlefield advantage, as space-based capabilities have become a critical strategic enabler for US forces.

Launch advances will enable new capabilities in space but risk deeper dependence on SpaceX. To date, launch demand far outweighs supply. SpaceX's Starship rocket launch marks the first launch of a fully reusable space vehicle with payloads to orbit. SpaceX still needs to conduct catch and reuse of the rocket and an end-to-end test. If successful, Starship will enable SpaceX to launch considerably more mass into orbit. The ability to increase launch capacity could improve the limited availability of commercial launch and reduce the cost. Launching greater mass into space could enable wide-ranging national security, scientific, and commercial applications, including for in-space manufacturing, which would be a pivotal breakthrough for the biotech and pharmaceutical industries.

Despite the possibility of lower launch costs, SpaceX's lead in this area could become a chokepoint if the company opts to leverage access. Many US and global companies are dependent on SpaceX for launch capabilities. Its recent launch advancements could incentivize SpaceX to raise costs on satellite companies, cementing its leadership in launch capabilities and satellite deployments.

Weak space governance will exacerbate orbital constraints. While launch capacity is improving, orbital constraints remain. On the way into orbit, one of Starship's six engines failed to burn properly, emphasizing the importance of engine reliability and redundancy. Additionally, real-time evaluations prompted SpaceX to cut the orbital test short. For deep-space and lunar operations, orbital refueling remains a limiting factor. These technical challenges are exacerbated by political ones. The lack of space governance structures exacerbates orbital challenges, including the overcrowding of space and the proliferation of space debris. Space governance, primarily guided by Cold War-era agreements, has not caught up to the capabilities and activities in space, and countries have little incentive to impose rules and limit their own activity in an increasingly strategic domain.

Satellite derisking efforts will continue—and shift up the value chain to launch. Concerns about dependence on SpaceX and its owner Elon Musk have helped to drive the pursuit of sovereign Low Earth Orbit (LEO) capabilities (See: Massive SpaceX IPO will push rivals to close widening gap , 20 April 2026). The EU (IRIS2), Amazon (Leo), and China (Guowang, Qianfan) have all ramped up efforts in the last year, while Russia started deploying its Rassvet constellation earlier in 2026.

These programs will continue, but with many companies dependent on SpaceX rockets for launch, derisking also will extend to launch capabilities. Canada and the UK are developing new spaceports, and Germany's Isar Aerospace reached orbit from Norway in Europe's first fully commercial orbital launch in September. Launch does remain a chokepoint for Beijing. Although China reached a critical milestone in July when it became the second country to recover an orbital booster, it has yet to sufficiently ramp up capacity to hit its targets for its two megaconstellations.

These nascent efforts indicate competition is coming for SpaceX. But with a large war chest from its spring IPO, ownership of a majority of spacecraft in LEO, and a new launch capability, SpaceX's momentum will give it power to set norms and exert leverage over its customers, including the US government.

Frontier reusable space vehicle capability would give the US a key battlefield advantage. Space-based capabilities have become a critical strategic enabler for US forces. During the Iran conflict, military satellites supported precision navigation and targeting, secure communications, and missile warning. Russia's long-range strikes against Ukrainian targets and China's long-range precision-strike capabilities also depend on satellite communications and navigation. As space becomes highly contested, especially in a great-power conflict, those capabilities make military satellite constellations increasingly valuable targets.

Cheaper and more frequent launches would allow the US to replace destroyed satellites and repair damaged on-orbit military communications and intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance (ISR) satellites faster than its adversaries. That advantage would give the US a qualitative edge. More frequent launches would also help advance persistent ISR, or uninterrupted monitoring of the Earth's surface, although the US would still need improvements in sensor production, onboard data processing, and downlink bandwidth. Persistent ISR would give US forces continuous situational awareness, deny adversaries concealment, and improve targeting speed and accuracy.

Lunar transport capability would anchor US presence in the increasingly contested cislunar domain. Over time, SpaceX plans to use Starship to replace Falcon 9, its current launch vehicle, and to carry astronauts to the Moon and beyond, as well as support US government and national security missions. Although SpaceX is leading in this capability now, the Pentagon is also backing Amazon Leo and United Launch Alliance as alternatives to SpaceX in LEO and launch. But even if its competitors start to catch up, SpaceX's early progress could lead to vendor lock-in for at least a product life cycle.

Carisa Nietzsche

Senior Analyst, Geo-technology

+1 202.540.5127

nietsche@eurasiagroup.net

Reed Cohen

Analyst, Geostrategy

cohen@eurasiagroup.net

Scott Bade

Senior Analyst, Geo-technology

+1 202.540.5140

bade@eurasiagroup.net

Michael Dempsey

Senior Advisor

dempsey.sa@eurasiagroup.net

EG Geo-technology

geo-technology@eurasiagroup.net

EG Aerospace & Defense

aerospacedefense@eurasiagroup.net

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